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The Orientation in the Orient (1949–1952)

> *Divergences between United States and Indian views toward China and Indochina are serious foreign policy conflicts blocking closer understanding with India.*
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> —Department of State policy statement, December 1, 1950[1]

On October 11, 1949, at 4:40 p.m., Indian prime minister Jawaharlal Nehru stepped off US president Harry Truman's plane *Independence* onto the tarmac at Washington's National Airport. *Time* called it "one of the century's most important visits of state."[2] It was Nehru's first visit to the United States and the first summit level meeting between the American and Indian heads of government. Truman, along with three cabinet ministers and a 19-gun salute, greeted Nehru at the airport. The skies were cloudless; from Truman's perspective, however, the state of the world was not. Just ten days earlier, Chinese Communist Party chairman Mao Zedong had announced the establishment of the People's Republic of China. This "loss" of China shaped the welcome Nehru received in the US, put the subject on the Truman-Nehru agenda and affected how India and her prime minister were seen in the US.

Despite the sunny beginning that day, China cast a dark shadow on the US-India relationship in the few years after the Truman-Nehru meeting. From 1949 to 1956, American and Indian policymakers differed over the